especially since they were dealing with left-wing criticism of the Sino-US rapprochement. They rejected the language of a communiqué, leaving the US to consider canceling Ford's scheduled visit.[73]

Kissinger was concerned about the slowdown, but the administration was unable to overcome domestic political constraints. He continued to seek Pakistani assessments about developments in China and Beijing's attitude toward the US.[74] Kissinger did not like what he heard. Pakistani policymakers noted that China was losing patience with the US.[75] Even the Indian ambassador told the secretary of state that Chinese officials in Washington were indicating their disappointment with the administration.[76] A frustrated Kissinger told Pakistani officials to convey to China that its criticism and anti-American propaganda were making it harder for the administration to sell China policy.[77] With Ford preparing for a December 1975 visit to Beijing and China playing hardball, Kissinger felt that the president needed to show firmness. He thought Ford's visits to the Philippines and Indonesia could be appropriate "jabs" at Beijing. When the president asked about adding India to make a point, however, Kissinger said no, that would be "too big a shock."[78]

In Beijing, to keep Chinese officials interested, the administration tried to highlight India as a potential problem again. Ford mentioned his disapproval of Delhi's approach to Tibet. Deng, however, dismissed it as insignificant. More galling for Kissinger must have been the Chinese leader's insistence that the US was part of the problem in the subcontinent. Kissinger had asserted that the US expected India to attack Bangladesh and Pakistan within the next five years—even though few, if any, in the US government thought this was likely, and Kissinger himself had told Pakistani prime minister Bhutto that India was not expansionist. Deng turned around and told him that the problem was the US, which was not doing enough for Pakistan at that time, just as it had not done enough in 1971.[79]

By spring 1976, China and India moved toward normalizing relations and exchanged ambassadors. That year Gandhi made it a point to sign the condolence book at the Chinese mission after the deaths of Mao and Zhou. The government also offered assistance to victims of the Tangshan earthquake in July.[80] But then political changes in India halted the momentum that those steps had created.